

or even word processing and data processing applications. The sole objective of using these is to reduce time and effort in doing non-functional tasks and concentrate on the core application. A lot of these tools are heavily misused or not used to their full potential primarily because we do not very easily see them directly as important to our application. This is a significant mistake as often on closer and more detailed inspection it is observed that had the supporting tools of the application been used in its intended manner the resulting error might have been easily detected or not have occurred in the first place.

Dos and Dont's for tools used in Software Development

UML Design tool

As obvious from its name, these tools are mostly used in the design phase to form the structure of the entire application using Unified Modelling Language to depict all its individual components, cluster them into modules, define the relationships between these modules clearly and expose all of its APIs in a neat and readable manner.

Be Concise

Large diagrams that contain tons of elements actually tend to convey less information than smaller focussed diagrams. When reading a large diagram your intended audience will be distracted and not know what to focus on, and since there's too much on there, they will quickly give up trying altogether.

A minimalist UML diagram is what you should put on your design review sheet. As a simple rule of thumb one can check if they are able to print the diagram on a single A4 sheet while keeping things readable.

Never Cross

Always try to avoid two lines crossing each other in your diagram. Uncrossing lines in a diagram makes it a lot more readable and understandable. More importantly, If you are unable to uncross the lines on the diagram then it is possible that:

- a) there's too much content on the diagram.
- b) there is some kind of design flaw in your model.

Parents Up

While drawing hierarchies on a diagram make sure to place the parent elements higher than the child elements so the arrows always point upwards.